manage conflict without the dangers inherent in the political. Although these efforts are for the most part well intended, in view of the hugely detrimental effects of conflict on the lives of millions in Myanmar, naïve insistence that consensus can be reached by negating the antagonism of the political not only puts the potential for democratic life at risk, but also may increase the likelihood of more violent conflict in the long run. Antagonism is not eliminated, but may instead be suppressed and then re-expressed in basically nonpolitical forms.

These nonpolitical forms, both formal and informal, constitute the other threat that is posed to the political at the current moment in Myanmar. The denial of the political encourages the formation of new groupings that speak the language of politics but attack its institutions; groupings that decline to recognize any kind of political relationship with those towards whom their hostility is directed, that refuse to relate to others' historical and contingent difference by acknowledging and negotiating it, even if the solutions obtained are temporary and for nobody altogether satisfactory.

Like "democracy to come", the promise of the political in some sense must always remain an unfulfilled promise, not because it will be forever deferred but because it is both antagonistic and aporetic — constituted by conflict and uncertainty. But it is the promise of the political that generates and is recognizable in the responses of people in Myanmar to conditions of inequality, and thus that realizes its own possibility. It is the task of scholars of contemporary Myanmar to be attentive both to that possibility, and what it signals for conflict, which is to say, for the political, while being alert to the forces that militate against it.

Notes

1 See also the chapters on the roles in the election of the Union Election Commission, international agencies and the military by Chaw Chaw Sein (2016), and on the Rakhine State election results and ethno-nationalism by Than Tun (2016).

2 Mouffe in dialogue with Carl Schmitt (2007, p. 26), which is why she emphasizes the antagonistic quality of the political. But whereas for Schmitt antagonism is rooted in the distinction between friend and enemy, and the possibility of war, Mouffe argues for a productive antagonism, one that will avoid precisely the danger that Schmitt (2007, pp. 32–33) envisages: the culmination of antagonism in a rudimentary struggle for destruction of the enemy.